	MANAGEMENT OF NON-CONFORMING WORK	
	Document no: ASMF7.17	
Compiled by:	Sifiso Nyambi - Laboratory Manager	
Approved by:	Nonhlanhla Msibi - Operations Manager	

Applies to: All stages of Proficiency Testing Scheme, testing, and reference material, (RM or CRM) production including sampling, characterization, homogeneity, stability, certification, labelling, and distribution.

1. Purpose

To define the procedure for identifying, documenting, evaluating, correcting, and preventing recurrence of any non-conforming work (NCW) that could affect the quality, integrity, or validity of certified reference materials (CRMs) or candidate RMs. This also extends to the testing section of the lab (ISO 17025, sampling, testing, ensuring validity of results, and reporting).

2. Scope

This applies to:
- PT and RM/CRM batches failing stability or homogeneity requirements
- Incorrect property value assignments or uncertainty estimations
- Equipment malfunction affecting measurement validity
- Labelling, packaging, or CoA errors
- Any deviation from production or testing procedures
- Incorrect traceability or documentation
- All requirements associated with ISO 17025.

3. Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Lab Manager	Authorize containment and initiate investigation
Lab Supervisor	Lead root cause analysis and maintain NCW register
Lab analyst/ operator	Report and document non-conforming work immediately
Operations Manager	Approve final corrective actions and ensure traceability of decisions

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4. Identification of non-conformity

Sources may include:
• Observation during routine work or supervision
• Internal audits
• Stability/homogeneity test failures
• Customer complaints
• Out-of-spec test results
• Incorrect CoA's or labelling errors

5. Initial Actions

• Immediately halt use of affected PT or RM/CRM or analysis or process step.
• Label the product or isolate the equipment with "NON-CONFORMING" tags.
• Notify the Laboratory/Operations Manager.
• Use ASMF 8.7.3 or SANAS F03-09 Improvement Action request form.

6. Documentation

The Improvement Action request form shall log the following:
• Unique NCW ID
• Date/time of detection
• Process stage affected
• Description of non-conformance
• Responsible person(s)
• Immediate action taken (containment), If necessary, ensure notification to customers within 24 hours of recording an NCW
• Signature of person reporting

ADDED:
• Root cause(s) identified
• Corrective action(s) taken
• Evidence of implementation

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• Planned date for effectiveness review
• Results of effectiveness review
• Date of closure

7. Evaluation and Risk Assessment

Assess whether the non-conformance:
• Affects previously released PT or RMs/CRMs
• Affects previously released reports/work/samples tested
• Requires rework, retesting, or full recall
• Risks invalidating assigned property values or traceability
• Has occurred before (recurring issue)
Use a risk matrix to evaluate severity and urgency.

8. Corrective Actions

Once root cause is confirmed:
• Define the correction and corrective action
• Assign responsible personnel and target dates
• Validate effectiveness after implementation
• Document updates to SOPs, training, or process controls if needed

ADDED:
• Where necessary, changes to the management system (procedures, work instructions, risk registers, or controls) shall be implemented to prevent recurrence of the non-conformance.
• Appropriate corrective actions shall be proportional to the risk and impact of the non-conforming work.
• All corrective actions shall be traceable to the identified root cause.

• Where necessary:

- Ensure notification of customers and recall CRM's/RM's and certificates and documentation within an appropriate period. This also means that any tested samples which can have a significant impact on the operations of customers shall be relayed to the client.
- PT reports already sent to participants are recalled or disregarded.

9. Follow-Up and Closure

• Verify the corrective action eliminated or mitigated the issue
• Retest or recharacterize RM/CRM/sample batch if necessary
• Document closure with review sign-off from operations/lab manager and resume work.
• Update NCW register and archive all records securely
• A planned Internal Audit must include the checking or evaluate the corrective action taken, this it ensures effectiveness of the implementation

ADDED:
• Effectiveness of corrective actions shall be evaluated after a suitable period of implementation to confirm that the non-conformance has not recurred and that process performance has improved.
• Effectiveness shall be verified by review of subsequent test results, repeat stability or homogeneity testing (where applicable), audit findings, or trend analysis of NCW records.
• The outcome of the effectiveness review shall be recorded on the Improvement Action Request form prior to formal closure of the NCW.

10. Timelines

• Major NCs shall be closed within 24 hours from the time of detection.
• Minor NCs shall be closed within 7 days from the time of detection.

ADDED:
• Effectiveness of corrective actions for **Major NCs** shall be reviewed within **1 to 3 months**, depending on the nature and risk of the non-conformance.

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• Effectiveness of corrective actions for **Minor NCs** shall be reviewed within **3 to 6 months** after implementation.
• Where justified by the nature of the non-conformance (e.g. long-term stability, trend monitoring), extended review periods may be defined and documented.

11. Record Retention

• NCW records must be stored for minimum of 10 years, linked to batch records.
• Include them in management review for trend analysis.

ADDED:
• Records shall include the nature of the non-conformance, root cause(s), corrective actions taken, planned and actual effectiveness review dates, and results of effectiveness verification.
• Corrective action records shall be available for verification during internal audits and external assessments.

12. Revision

Revision no	Content changed	Reason for the change	Date
02	Update the timelines for the closing of NCs.	NC raised by SANAS	06/02/2026
03	No content changed, just additions to address SANAS findings. (Please see sections 6,8,9,10,11 for the updates- look for “added” subheadings).	To address NC’s raised by SANAS.	11/02/2026

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